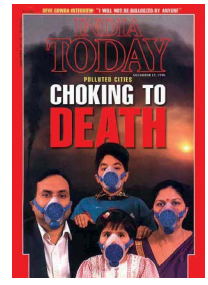
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

I have a confession to make. I am obsessed with AQI, or Air Quality Index. This should not be surprising because, for the past five decades, I have lived in probably the most polluted city in the world, certainly with the worst air in India. Yes, the capital city of India—Delhi. On November 28, its air was no longer in the 'severe' category. The AQI had dipped from 395 the previous day to 312. The irony is that this 55,000 sq. km urban sprawl breathed a sigh of relief because the air had *improved* to over three times worse than permissible. It was Delhi's worst November in eight years, with an average AQI of 377, and 11 days that saw the megacity plunge into the 'severe' category above AQI 400. What amazes me is that Delhi is where all the powers that be—the political class, the bureaucrats and the judiciary—reside. They have the power to do something about a problem that stares them in the face daily, but all we see is finger-pointing. Sadly, this is no longer just a Delhi story, hundreds of millions of Indians across the map breathe fiendishly toxic air.



December 15, 1996



March 16, 2015



December 28, 2015

So, what's new? We are used to living in the gradient between bad and worse, with a particular Indian mindset that normalises misery so much that nothing ever seems to change. Our first cover story on pollution was 27 years ago (*Choking to Death*, December 15, 1996). Since then, we have done two other cover stories. Although there is a dismal sense of deja vu as we pick through the facts again for this issue's cover story, there has been one critical difference. There's a qualitative swing in awareness, perhaps because the problem has become omnipresent across the country and there is far more research on its effect on health. Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee lends depth to our understanding on this front, detailing the latest medical insights on what smog does to our bodies. It's not just shortness of breath, which is bad enough. Bad air changes us on the inside and triggers a host of critical bodily phenomena. Going way deeper than respiratory problems, smog is now empirically correlated to diabetes, heart attack, renal decline, memory impairment, age-related macular degeneration in the eyes, microbiome imbalance of the stomach, prostate and colorectal cancers. Not to forget the first port of call: lung cancer and chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD). That's a truly multi-pronged attack on the body.

The COVID-19 pandemic has increased our sensitivity to how interrelated our vulnerabilities are. We haven't been able to solve the blight of pollution, but we should be thankful for small mercies. Our vigil has become sharper. Since 2015, AQI has been measured nationwide, and there are 804 monitoring stations now. And their readings are no longer 'soft news' on the side, it's the big headline. In lock-step with that, governments have started being more responsive, both at the state level and at the Centre. In January 2019, the Centre launched the National Clean Air Programme in 131 cities where air pollution exceeded permissible levels and allotted nearly Rs 20,000 crore to be spent until FY26 for mitigation. Midway into the plan, 90 cities have shown enhanced air quality, and 15 now meet prescribed standards.

I wish I could use the old cliche, 'Change is in the air', in a literal way, but the opposite is the case. Hellish levels of pollution once used to be the fate of mostly Delhi-NCR because of its unique 'air trap' syndrome and of a few industrial cities. Recently, the wider Gangetic plains caught up because of a cocktail of pollution and winter fog. Today, smog is everywhere. Count the concentrations of suspended particulate matter, and 10 Indian cities figure in the global Top 12. Mumbai has entered our new dystopian future: its rising skyline has blocked off wind from the sea, and the megalopolis has seen its dirtiest winter this year. Looking at Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data for 242 cities on November 14, only 40 cities were in the 'satisfactory' to 'good' range. We have nationalised pollution. And it's not just the stark fact of 202 cities living in shades of toxicity. The worst data these days often comes from places far from your typical urban nightmares. On November 14, Bharatpur, in the lap of the Aravallis and boasting one of India's biggest bird sanctuaries, was No. 1 at AQI 405. Rubbing shoulders with it was Dholpur, along the famously unpolluted waters of the Chambal, and Churu, both at 404.

Why is pollution spreading? Why are mitigation policies not working? And what must we do? It seems like a formidable complex of factors there. There are multiple reasons for pollution, which vary from region to region. Still, we break it down into four key components that are the most culpable: automobiles, agriculture, power and construction. Our accompanying story, anchored by Managing Editor M.G. Arun along with Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan and Associate Editor Avishek G. Dastidar, with inputs from all state bureaus, provides possible solutions to this vexatious problem. We have examples from across the world. London, New York, Paris, Seoul and Bangkok have seen a turn for the better. Even Colombia and Ghana pay to clean up their acts in Bogota and Accra. India must join that list.

We have six fundamental rights enshrined in the Indian Constitution. We should add one more: Breathe Clean Air.



(Aroon Purie)